

Guidelines on Process Writing

Process writing refers to a method of writing that emphasizes the **stages writers go through while composing a text**, rather than focusing only on the final product of writing.

The process usually includes:

1. Planning (Pre-writing)
2. Drafting
3. Responding (Feedback)
4. Revising
5. Editing
6. Evaluating
7. Post-writing

These stages are **recursive**, meaning writers may return to earlier stages whenever necessary. Good writers often move back and forth between planning, drafting, and revising.

Practicing process writing helps:

- develop ideas gradually
- improve clarity of expression
- refine arguments
- produce well-structured academic writing

1. Stage One: Planning (Pre-Writing)

Planning helps writers **generate ideas and organise their thoughts before writing**. It prevents the problem of facing a blank page.

Strategies for Planning

i. Brainstorming

Generate as many ideas as possible about a topic without worrying about correctness.

Example Topic:

Effects of Social Media on Students

Brainstormed ideas may include:

- communication
- distraction
- online learning
- cyberbullying

- networking
- news access
- mental health

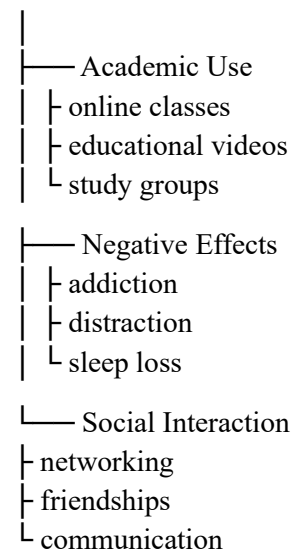
The aim is idea generation, not evaluation, and hence write down whatever ideas or concepts that come to your mind.

ii. Clustering (Mind Mapping)

Visually organise related ideas into groups or clusters. This helps in arranging and organising the different ideas.

Example cluster:

Social Media



Clustering helps **see relationships between ideas**.

iii. Rapid Free Writing

Write continuously for **1–2 minutes** about a topic without stopping.

Example:

Social media has become part of student life. Many students use it to communicate with friends and share information. However it can also distract them from studies and reduce concentration during lectures.

Free writing helps overcome **writer's block**. Do not worry about repeating ideas or grammatical mistakes at this stage. The idea is to write down everything that comes to your mind related to the ideas noted down above.

iv. WH-Questions Method

Generate questions to explore a topic.

Example Topic: **Online Learning**

- **What** is online learning?
- **Who** benefits from it?
- **Where** is it most effective?
- **When** did it become popular?
- **Why** is it important today?
- **How** does it affect students?

These questions (What, Who, Where, When, Why, How) help **develop ideas for paragraphs**.

2. Stage Two: Drafting

Drafting involves **writing the first version of the text** based on the ideas gathered during planning.

At this stage:

- focus on **ideas and meaning**
- do **not worry about grammar**
- write quickly and freely

Guidelines for Drafting

1. Identify your **main idea (thesis statement)**.
2. Write an **introduction** that introduces the topic.
3. Develop **body paragraphs with supporting details**.
4. End with a **conclusion**.

(Use the previous class notes and discussions on how to write effective paragraphs on a topic.)

Example (First Draft)

Topic: **Effects of Social Media on Students**

Familiarity with social media is a necessity for students in today's world (**thesis statement**). First and foremost, social media enables students not only to connect with their friends and peers, but also interact and approach academicians, experts, scholars, professionals and others who might be of help to them in pursuing their goals (**Supporting argument 1**). Secondly, social media has also replaced traditional channels for news and current affairs (**Supporting argument 2**). And most importantly, social media provides a platform to today's youth to express themselves and display their creativity and imagination, to a wide audience, get feedback from others and monetise their talents (**Supporting argument 3**). Thus, knowledge and proficiency in using social media is of utmost importance for

students without which they may miss out on some of the most significant opportunities in their life
(**Concluding sentence**).

This draft may contain language errors but the **focus is idea development**.

3. Stage Three: Responding (Feedback)

Responding involves **feedback from teachers or peers on the first draft**.

This feedback helps the writer improve ideas before revising.

Teachers and peers should give **constructive comments**, not just corrections.

Example of Feedback

Original sentence:

Social media is bad for students.

Teacher/Peer Response:

- Why is it bad?
- Can you give examples?
- Is it always harmful?

This encourages the writer to **develop arguments more clearly**.

Peer Review Questions

Students may ask the following questions while reviewing a classmate's work:

- What is the main idea of the essay?
- Which part is most interesting?
- Which part needs more explanation?
- Where is the argument unclear?
- Where should examples be added?

4. Stage Four: Revising

Purpose

Revising means **improving the content and organisation of writing**.

It is not simply correcting grammar.

During revision students should:

- clarify ideas
- reorganise paragraphs
- add explanations or examples
- remove unnecessary information

Example of Revision

First Draft Sentence:

Social media is bad for students.

Revised Version:

Excessive use of social media can negatively affect students because it distracts them from academic work and reduces their concentration.

Revision improves **clarity and precision**.

Useful Revision Techniques

1. **Read your essay aloud**
This helps identify unclear sentences.
2. **Rewrite from memory**
Rewriting helps strengthen ideas rather than copying the previous draft.
3. **Exchange drafts with classmates**

These methods help writers see their work from a **reader's perspective**.

5. Stage Five: Editing

Purpose

Editing focuses on **surface errors** such as grammar, spelling, punctuation, and sentence structure.

This stage occurs **after revision**, so that attention to grammar does not interrupt the writing process.

Editing Checklist for Students

Before submitting your essay, ask yourself:

- Are the **verb tenses** correct?
- Is **subject–verb agreement** correct?
- Are **sentences complete**?
- Is **punctuation** used correctly?
- Are **spelling errors** corrected?

- Are **pronouns and prepositions** used properly?

Example

Incorrect:

Students uses social media everyday and it affect their study.

Edited:

Students **use** social media **every day**, and it **affects** their studies.

6. Stage Six: Evaluating

Purpose

Evaluation is done by the teacher to assess the final piece of writing. But evaluation can also be done by classmates or peers, and if needed one can also evaluate one's own writing (Take a few days off and go back to your draft and read it with a fresh and objective mindset).

Evaluation may consider:

- Significance or importance of the topic
- relevance of arguments to the topic
- clarity of ideas
- organisation
- vocabulary
- grammar and punctuation
- overall effectiveness of communication.

Teachers may use **analytical scoring** (separate marks for each aspect) or **holistic scoring** (overall impression).

Students may also practice **self-evaluation** to improve their writing skills.

7. Stage Seven: Post-Writing Activities

After completing the writing task, students may:

- read their essays aloud
- display them on notice boards
- publish them in class magazines
- perform them as speeches or presentations.

These activities make writing **purposeful and meaningful**. They also encourage us to become better writers.

Practical Tips for Writers

1. Do not aim for perfection in the first draft.
2. Write regularly to improve fluency.
3. Seek feedback from teachers and peers.
4. Revise multiple times.
5. Use digital tools (Grammarly, MS Word spelling and grammar check, etc) for easy revision.
6. Always consider your audience while writing.

Reference:

“The Writing Process and Process Writing” by Anthony Seow in *Methodology in Language Teaching: An Anthology of Current Practice* edited by Jack C. Richards and Willy A. Renandya. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2002.

8. Exercise:

Topic: “The Importance of Critical Thinking in University Education”

PART 1: PRE-WRITING (PLANNING)

A. Brainstorming

Write **any words or phrases** that come to your mind when you think about **critical thinking in university education**.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____
7. _____
8. _____

B. Clustering (Idea Map)

Write the topic in the centre and group related ideas around it. Arrange and organise the ideas into different categories and try to show the link or connection among those ideas.

C. WH–Questions

Answer the following questions to explore the topic.

What is critical thinking?

Why is critical thinking important for university students?

How does critical thinking help students in their studies?

Where do students use critical thinking in academic life?

When do students need critical thinking skills most?

PART 2: DRAFTING

Write a **short essay or paragraph (150–200 words)** based on your ideas.

Remember:

- Focus on **ideas and meaning**
- Do **not worry about grammar mistakes yet**
- Include:
 - an introduction
 - supporting ideas
 - examples
 - concluding sentence

PART 3: PEER RESPONSE

Exchange your draft with a partner.

Your partner should read your draft and answer the following questions.

Peer Feedback Questions

1. What is the **main idea** of the essay?

2. Which part of the essay is **most interesting or clear**?

3. Which idea needs **more explanation or examples**?

4. Is any part **confusing or unclear**?

5. What suggestion would you give to improve this essay?

PART 4: REVISING

Based on your partner's feedback, revise your essay.

Think about:

- adding examples
- clarifying unclear ideas
- reorganising sentences or paragraphs
- removing unnecessary information

Write **two improvements** you will make:

1. _____
2. _____

Rewrite one improved paragraph below:

PART 5: EDITING

Now check your essay for **language accuracy**.

Tick ✓ when you have checked each item.

Editing Checklist ✓

I checked verb tenses

I checked subject–verb agreement

I corrected spelling mistakes

Editing Checklist



I used punctuation correctly

I wrote complete sentences

I checked the use of articles (a, an, the)

PART 6: REFLECTION

Answer the following questions.

1. What was the **most difficult part** of writing this essay?

2. What did you **improve after revision**?

3. What will you try to improve in your **next piece of writing**?

Optional Post-Writing Activity

Choose one of the following:

- Read your essay aloud to the class.
- Exchange essays with another group for discussion.
- Publish the draft on your blog and share it with your friends for reviews and comments.
